

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

1992-06-07

To the bahá'ís of the world

1 As we reflect on the events which a few days ago marked the commemora-
2 tion in the holy land of the centenary of the Ascension of bahá'u'lláh, we
3 feel impelled to express to the bahá'í world our sense of wonderment at the
4 exalted character of what transpired. The nature of the Anniversary was in
5 itself awe-inspiring and evocative of profound emotion. but the gathering
6 of some 3,000 bahá'ís, including 113 knights of bahá'u'lláh, representing
7 no less than 200 countries and dependent territories—the widest diversity of human
beings ever to have assembled on a bahá'í occasion—filled the
8 eyes with the vision of a garden of humanity that overwhelmed the senses,
9 inducing a spirit of beauty, joy and splendor. bahjí was never more resplen-
10 dent. And we offer prayers of thanksgiving to our beloved lord that so
11 fitting an assemblage could have been realized on this special Anniversary, indicating
the amazing extent to which the pervasive power of his influence
12 has triumphed throughout the world.
13 may the evident blessings flowing from this heavenly experience infuse
14 the dear friends everywhere with new strength and fresh encouragement,
emboldening their efforts and enlarging their capacity to proclaim the
15 Name and promote the cause of bahá'u'lláh during the course of the holy
16 year so auspiciously begun.

On the Occasion of the Centenary Commemoration at Bahjí

of the Ascension of Bahá'u'lláh

A Tribute by the Universal House of Justice 131-1

with soul-stirring emotion we gather in the hallowed environs of his

17 resting place to honor the memory of the Supreme manifestation of god,

bahá'u'lláh, on the solemn, historic occasion of the centenary of his

18 ascension.

19 131-1. The following text was read on the occasion of the ceremony at bahjí on the
20 morning of 28 may 1992 for the placement of the roll of honor of the knights of

bahá'u'lláh at the entrance door of the most holy Shrine.131.1

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132 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

133 276we lift our voices at the prompting of our hearts' desire to pay tribute to
134 a life infinitely beyond compare. but how shall we realize such a wish when
135 it is evident that no mind can attain the comprehension which would make
136 possible the vocabulary worthy of his celestial court? in very truth, our

137 tongues falter in their impotence to describe, let alone extol, the prodigies of a
prophetic career which was framed in superlatives. for here at bahjí, one

138 hundred years ago, was drawn the last breath on earth of the world's greatest
luminary, founder of the dispensation marking the culmination of the

139 six-thousand-year-old Adamic cycle, and inaugurator of the five-thousand-

140 century bahá'í cycle. he, the most great manifestation, appeared in the

141 most great Name and endured the greatest suffering in authoring the most

142 great revelation, which is the wellspring of the most great peace. in our at-

143 tempt to appreciate these matchless bounties, we recite the gem-like names

144 of the Adored one, picked out as pearls from the veritable ocean of his

145 revelation, bestrewing them throughout our testimonial that they may lend

146 an acceptable gleam to our expression of his glory and majesty.

147 king of kings, lord of lords, Supreme mediator, most Ancient beauty:

he is the well-beloved of all worlds. we hail him as the long-awaited

148 promised one, the object of the adoration of the world. And we exclaim:

"hallowed be the lord in whose hand is the source of dominion!"

149 131-2

how grievously bahá'u'lláh suffered to regenerate the world! wrongly

150 accused, imprisoned, beaten, chained, banished from country to country, betrayed,
poisoned, stripped of material possessions, and "at every moment

151 tormented with a fresh torment”: such was the cruel reception that greeted the
everlasting father, him who is the possessor of all Names and Attri-
152 butes. for two score years, until the end of his earthly days, he remained a
153 prisoner and exile—persecuted unceasingly by the rulers of persia and the
154 ottoman empire, opposed relentlessly by a vicious and scheming clergy,
155 neglected abjectly by other sovereigns to whom he addressed potent letters
156 imparting to them that which, in his truth-bearing words, “is the cause of
157 the well-being, the unity, the harmony, and the reconstruction of the world, and of
the tranquility of the nations.” “m y grief,” he once lamented, “ex-
158 ceedeth all the woes to which jacob gave vent, and all the afflictions of job
are but a part of m y sorrows.”

159 131-3

160 131-2. Swb, 7:1.2.

161 131-3. pdc, p. 100; eSw , pp. 45, 77 .131.4

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132 1992–1993 • T h e h o l Y Ye a r

133 277The voice halts for shame from continuing so deplorable a recitation,
134 the heart is torn by mere thought of the divine Target of such grief—grief
135 no ordinary mortal could endure. but lest we give way to feelings of gloom
136 and distress, we take recourse in the tranquil calm he induces with such
137 meaningful words as these: “ we have borne it all with the utmost willing-
138 ness and resignation, so that the souls of men may be edified, and the word
139 of god be exalted.”131-4 Thus, the wronged one, patient beyond measure,
140 preserved a majestic composure, revealing his true Self as the merciful,
141 the loving, the incomparable friend. concentrating his energies on the
142 pivotal purpose of his revelation, he transmuted his tribulations into in-
143 struments of redemption and summoned all peoples to the banner of unity.
144 No worldly power could thwart the purpose of the most exalted pen.
145 Through the copiousness of his writings, he poured upon the planet the

healing waters of the word of god renewed. descending upon him like

a spring rain, his revelation comprises some one hundred volumes—

“volumes replete with unnumbered exhortations, revolutionizing prin-

146 ciples, world-shaping laws and ordinances, dire warnings and portentous
147 prophecies, with soul-uplifting prayers and meditations, illuminating com-mentaries
and interpretations, impassioned discourses and homilies, all
148 interspersed with either addresses or references to kings, to emperors and
149 to ministers, of both the east and the west, to ecclesiastics of divers de-
150 nominations, and to leaders in the intellectual, political, literary, mystical, commercial
and humanitarian spheres of human activity.” foremost among
151 his books is his kitáb-i-Aqdas, the charter of the future world civilization
152 in which he has announced the laws of god for this age. our hearts thrill
153 to the prospect that during the course of this centennial year, the annotated english
translation of this mother book of bahá’u’lláh’s revelation is to be
154 published. we acknowledge with astonished joy the prolific legacy of this
155 divine outpouring. And we exclaim: “p raised be Thou, who art the desire
156 of the world, and thanks be to Thee, o well-beloved of the hearts of such
as are devoted to Thee!”

157 131-5

158 Today, we bear witness to the further abundance of a peerless heritage.

with the setting of the Sun of bahá, the moon of his covenant rose in

159 reflected glory, lifting the darkness of a night of despair, and lighting the

160 131-4. eSw , pp. 76–77 .

161 131-5. gpb, p. 220; eSw , p. 43.131.7

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132 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

133 278path to the unity of all humankind. in the fullness of its radiance stands

134 the magnetic figure of ‘Abdu’l-b ahá, the beloved Son whom bahá’u’lláh

135 designated as the interpreter of his word and executive of his authority,

and whom he appointed the center of his covenant, an office without

136 parallel in all religious history.

we acknowledge the mysterious power of his wisdom, the illuminating

137 potency of his words, the immortal example and unific character of his
138 deeds. by his untiring exertions the fame of the infant cause was spread
139 abroad, the design of its Administrative order was completed, the world
140 center of the faith emerged into clear visibility, and the splendors of the
141 mountain of god, as alluded to in bahá'u'lláh's Tablet of carmel, began to
142 be manifested. with profound gratitude for such evident blessings we reaf-
143 firm our loyalty to the covenant of bahá'u'lláh. And we exclaim: "g lorified

be the All-merciful, the lord of g race abounding!"131-6

As a result of the phenomenal effects of his covenant, a world commu-

144 nity has been raised up on an "unassailable foundation."131-7 The entire sys-
145 tem of the Administrative order originated by bahá'u'lláh in his most holy
146 book has been erected. A vigorous network of local, national, continental
147 and international institutions functions in exemplary harmony throughout the planet.
vitalized and nurtured by his stupendous revelation, watered
148 by the precious blood of countless martyrs, and tended by the loving care of
149 unnumbered, devoted servants, the Tree of the cause has, in these hundred
150 years, grown mightily, has put forth its far-stretching branches and borne its
151 first and plentiful fruit.

bahá'u'lláh found the world in a "strange sleep."

152 131-8 but what a distur-
153 bance his coming has unloosed! The peoples of the earth had been separat-
154 ed, many parts of the human race socially and spiritually isolated. but the
155 world of humanity today bears little resemblance to that which bahá'u'lláh
156 left a century ago. unbeknownst to the great majority, his influence per-
157 meates all living beings. indeed, no domain of life remains unaffected. in
158 the burgeoning energy, the magnified perspectives, the heightened global
consciousness; in the social and political turbulence, the fall of kingdoms, the emancipation
of nations, the intermixture of cultures, the clamor for development; in the agitation over the
extremes of wealth and poverty, the

159 131-6. Tb, p. 21.

160 131-7 . Adj, ¶36.131-8. pdc, p. 6.131.10

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131 12
132 1992–1993 • T h e h o l Y Y e a r
133 279acute concern over the abuse of the environment, the leap of consciousness
134 regarding the rights of women; in the growing tendency towards ecumen-
135 ism, the increasing call for a new world order; in the astounding advances
136 in the realms of science, technology, literature and the arts—in all this tu-mult, with
its paradoxical manifestations of chaos and order, integration and disintegration, are the
signs of his power as world reformer, the proof
137 of his claim as divine physician, the truth of his word as the All-knowing
138 counselor.

bahá'u'lláh wrote voluminously about the purpose of this mysterious

139 force and its transformative effects, but the essence can be drawn from these

few perspicuous words: “Through the movement of our pen of glory we

140 have, at the bidding of the omnipotent ordainer, breathed a new life into
141 every human frame, and instilled into every word a fresh potency. All cre-ated things
proclaim the evidences of this worldwide regeneration.” And
142 again: “A new life is, in this age, stirring within all the peoples of the earth; and yet
none hath discovered its cause or perceived its motive.” And yet again: “h e who is the
unconditioned is come, in the clouds of light, that
143 he may quicken all created things with the breezes of his Name, the most
144 merciful, and unify the world, and gather all men around this Table which

hath been sent down from heaven.”

145 131-9
146 let the denizens of the earth wake from their slumber at the resonances
147 of his Name and arise from their confused dreams to embrace the clarity
148 of the new day: for “This is the king of days, the day that hath seen the
149 coming of the best-beloved, him who through all eternity hath been ac-
claimed the d esire of the w orld.”131-10

our thoughts turn back to the mourning time in 1892 when a vast num-

150 ber of residents from the surrounding area came to join his bereaved fol-
151 lowers in lamenting the departure of the immortal beloved. These were not

152 adherents of his cause and had no real understanding of his station, but
153 the effect of his presence among them was such as to fill them with a grave
154 sense of loss. Today, a century later, it is we, who identify ourselves with his
155 community, who have come in multitudinous array from the far corners of the earth
to pay homage to the king of glory. with us in spirit are the mil-

156 lions of his lovers scattered among tens of thousands of villages, towns and

157 131-9. Adj, ¶109; gwb, no. 96.2; eSw , p. 46.

158 131-10. wob, p. 106.131.13

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132 m e S a g e S f r o m T h e u n i v e r S a l h o u S e o f j u S T i c e

133 280 cities, themselves observing in their own localities this solemn anniversary,

134 their hearts focused on the p r i m a l Spot here at b a h í .

135 And among us at this point of Adoration are a number of the heroic souls

136 from the celebrated company who earned the accolade knight of bahá'u'lláh

conferred upon them by Shoghi effendi, guardian of the cause—this to

137 signify their acts of daring and devotion as teachers of the faith. it is they

138 who were in the vanguard during the triumphant Ten year world crusade.

139 Their exploits, built upon the dramatic feats of the heroic Age and the

140 sacrifices of countless martyrs and heroes of the past, and following the trail blazed
by earlier teachers of the faith, realized the actual establishment of

141 the cause of b a h á ' u ' l l á h as a world religion.

Now, on this commemorative occasion, the roll of honor on which the

142 names of the knights have been inscribed is being deposited by Amatu'l-

bahá rú'íyyih khánúm at the entrance door of the most holy Shrine in

143 the spot designated by our beloved guardian. This is both a symbol and a

144 promise—a symbol registering the reality of a clear response, at a critical time, to the
duty laid upon us by the lord of hosts to diffuse his teachings

145 among all peoples; a promise that the commitment so dazzlingly displayed by these
intrepid pioneers will be reaffirmed by generations of their succes-sors, ensuring that the
light of bahá'u'lláh's revelation, "shining in all its

power and glory, will have suffused and enveloped the entire planet."

146 131-11

147 This is also a mark of recognition of the power of the hand of omnipo-
148 tence to turn gnats into eagles. his bounties embolden us. broken-winged
149 birds are we; yet, with his assurances resounding in our souls, we soar to
150 ever greater heights in his service. "i am the royal falcon on the arm of the
151 Almighty!" he declares, benevolently adding: "i unfold the drooping wings
152 of every broken bird and start it on its flight."131-12 how then can we fail?

we here make this vow: with a stirring history of divine support be-

153 hind us and a clear vision of unfolding destiny before us, we move onward, renewed,
reconsecrated, resolute, until the consciousness of every human being has been touched by
the knowledge of god's triumphant faith. And,

154 intoning the expectant words of his martyr-h erald, we exclaim: "e xalted

155 be his glory, and magnified be his might, and sanctified be his holiness,

and glorified be h is grandeur, and lauded be h is ways!"

156 131-13

157 131-11. mbw , p. 155.

158 131-12. Tb, p. 169.

159 131-13. eSw , p. 153.131.16

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132 1992–1993 • T h e h o l Y Y e a r

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Passing of Isobel Sabri, Counselor Member of the

International Teaching Center

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]